

belong to the public domain and should remain there, free for everyone to access and celebrate.”

NEGOTIATING THE RETURN OF INDIA'S HERITAGE

In order to build Maazi, Kakkar and his team had to go deep into dialogues with western institutions that hold vast collections of South Asian art. “For instance,” he shares, “the Bodleian Library at Oxford University houses thousands of works that rightfully belong in Indian museums.”

The company reached out to the Bodleian to secure access to these archives. The library obliged, sharing a significant portion of its collection. Yet there was a catch: the images were licensed under a Creative Commons BY-NC 4.0 framework, which permits their use only with attribution and prohibits commercial activity.

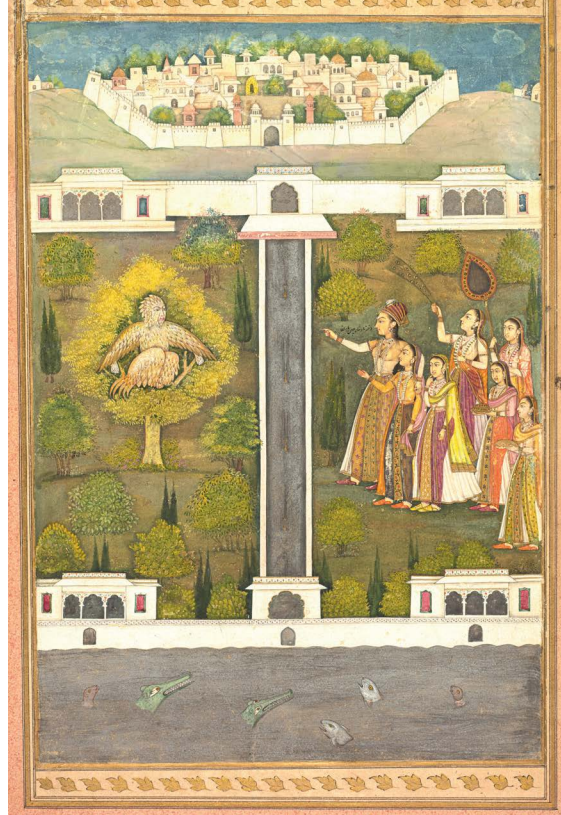
“We respectfully disagree with this restriction,” Kakkar says firmly. “It contradicts existing intellectual property laws and the very ethos of preservation. These artworks are in the public domain, and they should not be confined by licensing terms that stifle their reach.”

Most importantly, as Kakkar points out, the issue is also about pricing. “The prices are quite high. For instance, just to photograph a print from say the British Museum will cost you at least £85. Then comes licensing, which is even more oppressive. Such high pricing is forbidding for most Indians.”

Which is why, at Maazi Merchant, the pricing of these priceless works of art is low. For example, an archival print of *Three Princesses* would be about ₹1,899, with various upgrades available, going up to ₹7,499, with a white cedar cherry hardwood box frame and museum grade canvas and a larger size of 19 by 24.

And Kakkar’s prodigious output has begun to find resonance far and wide. Abhinit Khanna, Art Advisor & Project Specialist at the Reliance Industries Ltd, was one of Maazi Merchant’s earliest supporters. “When I first saw the prints, I was mesmerised,” Khanna says. “The history, quality of giclee prints, the richness of the colour—it was as though I was looking at the original works of art from the 18th & 19th century.”

Khanna, who has been at the forefront of curating art, producing exhibitions, introduced Kakkar’s work to his creative team at Reliance, paving the way for a landmark collaboration. “We were looking for something meaningful, something uniquely Indian for the Jamnagar pre-wedding



MALLIKA AND THE BIRD-MAN; C. 1710

₹3,999-
₹18,999 +
TAXES



MARATHA LIGHT CAVALRY; C. 1828

₹1,899-₹6,499 + TAXES

MAAZI MERCHANT IS FOCUSING ON RECLAIMING HISTORY, DISMANTLING COLONIAL GATEKEEPING, AND RESTORING HERITAGE BACK ON INDIAN WALLS